

United States Army Intelligence Center of Excellence

ENHANCING YOUR INTELLIGENCE WRITING

Army Writing Style Guide



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Chapter 1 Introduction

The US Army requires Soldiers to write clear, concise documents understood in a single, *rapid reading* (Headquarters, Department of the Army [HQDA], 2020). This requires Soldiers to be familiar with *AR 25-50 Preparing and Managing Correspondence*, the *Federal Plain Language Guidelines*, the *Army Style Guide*, and academic requirements for the coursework. Soldiers must also adapt their writing style for the audiences reading their work, which includes members of their military occupation specialty (MOS) and instructors.

Throughout your course, your instructor may task you with analyzing many different topics. How you research and write about that topic is up to you, but when you need help, this handbook can be a valuable guide.

The goal for this handbook is to help all USAICoE Soldiers master written communication in efficient intelligence products. In short, your coursework will help you *think* like an intelligence professional, while this handbook will help you *write* like one.

1-1. Army Writing Style

Before starting the writing process, there are a few things you must know about the Army Writing Style.

The standard guides are *AR 25-50* and the *Federal Plain Language Guide*. You will also write according to instructor requirements. This guide is here to help as you navigate through the various requirements.

Most of the papers or correspondence you will write will require the five following criteria:

- a. **Bottom line up front (BLUF)** – A BLUF states the purpose of the entire paper. It will be in the top 2% of the paper.
- b. **Concision** – Concision means writing in clear, short, easily understood sentences.
- c. **Accuracy** – Write accurately, with few or no grammar, spelling, wording, and formatting errors.
- d. **Voice** – Active voice is a requirement set forth by *AR 25-50*. Writing in active voice is important. It aids with concision and the rapid read.
- e. **Analysis** – Analysis asks you to question, evaluate, interpret, and integrate outside sources to offer a complete idea with resources to support the claim.

1-2. Need to Know Extras

Most Army writing assignments will require either Arial 12-point font or Times New Roman 12 point font. The margins of your paper will be one-inch margins on all sides. Most courses require either American Psychological Association (APA) or Chicago Manual of Style (CMOS) formatting guidelines. If you are unfamiliar with either, the Purdue Owl website is an excellent resource at https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/purdue_owl.html

1-3. Importance

Writing is an important part of the Intelligence Community. Writing will often require intelligence professionals to find and process large volumes of information, analyze the information to develop intelligence, and communicate their findings effectively. Good intelligence writing provides information to readers who will be making decisions based on that information.

Your goal is to write as an intelligence professional. It is important to utilize *AR 25-50* and instructor guidance when writing any course document. There are three things to consider when writing:

- a. **Purpose:** You must establish the purpose for your paper. Who is your audience? What do you want the reader to gain by reading it?
- b. **Concision:** Make the point as quickly, clearly, and as easily recognizable as possible.
- c. **Expectations:** Know the expectations and requirements set forth by *AR 25-50*, the rubric, and your instructor.

The Figure 1 diagram below shows the overlap between the three most common types of writing within USAICoE.

Figure 1

Types of Writing



1-4. Research

While it may be tempting to begin a research project online due to the sheer volume of research available on the internet, having a conversation with a librarian may be more useful. Advantages to consulting librarians include:

- a. Help in narrowing a research project appropriate for the assignment
- b. Full knowledge and expertise in local inventory within the library
- c. Awareness of interlibrary loan and subscriptions for materials outside the library
- d. Expertise in internet research, as well as ability to validate the reliability of sources
- e. Institutional visibility and connection to academic assistance programs for students who are struggling
- f. Expertise in study habits, research methods, and note-taking systems
- g. Access to computer labs, DVDs, and electronic media

1-5. Army Style Communication

According to *AR 25-50*, every Army document should be clear enough to read and understand in a single pass and be as short as possible without losing the meaning (HQDA, 2020). As such, the Army is clear about its priorities: time is at a premium and the readers expect the author (not the audience) to do most of the work.

While this handbook covers broad techniques, it is critical to remember the key to *good* writing is to adapt to the needs and expectations of your audience. Because your course will require a variety of writing tasks with different purposes and contexts for each, this handbook stresses principles for adaptability. Field practices may vary, but the principles will remain the same.

Intelligence professionals must be able to:

- a. Analyze sources to develop intelligence
- b. Find and process large volumes of information
- c. Communicate findings effectively

Currently, written communication is the focus of this handbook; however, these skills are interrelated as depicted in Figure 2. **Figure 2**

Key Communication Skills



Note: Writing, Reading, Briefing, and Listening. Improvement in any one area will help improve the others.

Chapter 2 Putting the Bottom Line Up Front

Good intelligence writing provides decision-making information to readers. To help readers, you must place the most important information first. *AR 25-50* calls this putting the *bottom line up front* (BLUF) (HQDA, 2020).

For any document, the front refers to its beginning. The front of a sentence is the first few words. The front of a paragraph contains the first few sentences. The front of a document includes the title or subject line and introduction.

Instructors watch for two items in your writing: the clarity of the bottom line purpose and its physical location in the document. The physical location of the BLUF will be the first sentence or within the top 2% of the document.

2-1. Bottom Line Up Front

The writer's top priority is to state the bottom line as soon as possible as required by each course. In Army writing, the reader, who is often your instructor, wants the writer to start with the claims then defend them.

In Army intelligence, the writer usually organizes the paper in the following manner:

- a. Bottom line up front (BLUF) – state the purpose of the paper, or what you want the reader to walk away with.

Example: BLUF– Cyber-attacks pose a significant threat to US national security.

- b. In addition to the BLUF, some papers may call for a thesis statement. A thesis statement is different from a BLUF. A thesis breaks down the paper into smaller points the writer will be discussing.

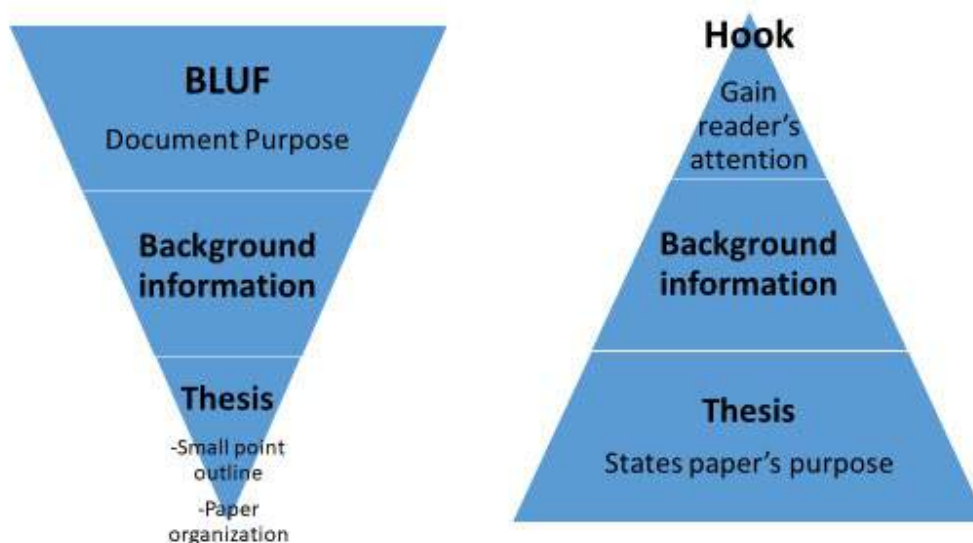
Example: Thesis- Adversaries frequently use cyber-attacks including phishing, ransomware and man-in-the-middle attacks against the US and its allies.

- c. Defend the claim or claims– using analysis, state how and why cyber-attacks pose a threat to US national security via phishing, ransomware, and man-in-the-middle attacks.
- d. Conclusion– Cyber-attacks pose a threat to US national security because...

Army writing is similar to the inverted pyramid structure. In the inverted pyramid, the important information is up front. The image in Figure 3 below demonstrates the differences in structure between Army writing and academic writing.

Figure 3

Army versus Academic



2-2. Titles

Papers often focus on providing information and analyzing that information. A concise title, similar to the BLUF, is important. While the title and the BLUF should differ, the main point of the paper must be evident within the title.

Titles should be short, clear, and concise. While the title may not reveal a bottom line, it does provide information necessary for the reader to get an idea of what the purpose of the paper will be.

- a. *Example:* North Korea's Cyber Capabilities

2-3. Purpose

Every assignment should have a well-defined purpose. Your audience should recognize the primary purpose immediately and secondary purposes should support the main one. Readers should care about the document and the information within it. Some purposes for writing include:

- a. **Analyze** – asks you to question, evaluate, interpret, and integrate outside sources to offer a complete idea with resources that support a claim or claims.

- b. **Persuade** – attempts to convince reader to agree with the writing by using emotions
- c. **Argue** – changing the mind of the reader to adopt an idea or course of action using facts, statistics, and figures
- d. **Inform** – sharing important knowledge with your audience
- e. **Report** – telling the audience why something happened or how something works
- f. **Present** – offering insight or wisdom from direct experience

Chapter 3 Concision

The goal for good intelligence writing is to develop clear and concise papers. Being concise means using only the necessary words to transmit information or an idea. Concision requires balancing the information you provide against the number of words you write, while maintaining the idea of the assignment.

3-1. Keeping it Simple

According to AR 25-50, use short words, keep sentences short, and avoid lengthy paragraphs (HQDA, 2020). All paragraphs should be no more than 10 lines and the average length of a sentence should be about 15 words (HQDA, 2020).

Concision decreases length and reduces confusion. It may also reduce errors in your writing. Concision keeps the assignment accurate, without unnecessary filler. Concision aids in the single, rapid read.

3-2. Redundancies, Inflated Phrases, and Emphatic Language

- a. Redundancies occur when sentences include information that duplicates ideas.

Example:

The unexpected surprise caught the Soldier off guard.

Using both unexpected and surprise makes this sentence redundant.

Correct Example:

The surprise caught the Soldier off guard.

- b. Inflated phrases happen when you use more words than necessary to make a point. Figure 4 provides examples of inflated phrases and their counterparts.

Figure 4

Inflated Phrases

Instead of saying	Say
due to the fact that	because
at the present time	currently, now
in order to	to
in spite of the fact that	although
by means of	by
be responsible for	must
is able to	can

- c. Emphatic language is including extra words for emphasis, to make a point.

Example (Incorrect): It is critical that all Soldiers examine their lockers for messy clutter.

Example (Correct): Soldiers must examine their lockers for clutter.

3-3. Concision Tips

Concision takes practice. Consolidating relevant information into the fewest number of words may seem challenging. Here are some tips to help:

- a. Get to the point
- b. Limit long words (three or more syllables)
- c. Avoid jargon, clichés, legalese, and colloquialisms
- d. Use precise concrete words rather than abstract or overly descriptive ones
- e. Keep sentences to an average length of 15 words
- f. Do not put more than one idea in a sentence
- g. Cut out wordy phrases and repetition
- h. Eliminate unnecessary modifiers (really, basically, actually)
- i. Eliminate redundancy (terrible tragedy, unexpected surprise, stealthy spy)
- j. Interrogate your words— if it does not support the purpose of the paper, remove it

Chapter 4 Accuracy

Accuracy refers to writing without errors in spelling, punctuation, word usage, and formatting. To be accurate is to be correct, credible, and complete. Errors in spelling, punctuation, usage, and formatting cause confusion, and the author loses credibility.

AR 25-50 states Army writing must be free of errors in grammar, mechanics, and usage (HQDA, 2020).

Soldiers should:

- a. Use correct standard written English, proper spelling, punctuation, and grammar.
- b. Use proper formatting in accordance with your writing assignment.
- c. Make sure the paper is complete in presenting all necessary information.
- d. Make sure the facts are correct.
- e. Check the logic and objectivity of the paper.

4-1. Parts of Speech

Standard English grammar recognizes nine functions for words in sentences, called parts of speech. Figure 5 reflects the nine parts of speech.

Figure 5

Parts of Speech

Part of Speech	Definition	Explanation
Noun	Person, place, thing or concept	Answers: who or what? Three types: 1. Common- any one of a group of people, places, things or concepts. 2. Proper- specific person, place, thing, or concept 3. Compound- two or more nouns joined to make one

Part of Speech	Definition	Explanation												
Pronoun	Takes the place of a noun	Answers: who or what? Type of pronouns: <table> <tr> <th></th><th>Singular</th><th>Plural</th></tr> <tr> <td>1st person</td><td>I, me, my, mine</td><td>we, us, our, ours</td></tr> <tr> <td>2nd person</td><td>your, yours</td><td>you, your</td></tr> <tr> <td>3rd person</td><td>He, him, his, she, her, it</td><td>they, them, their, theirs</td></tr> </table>		Singular	Plural	1st person	I, me, my, mine	we, us, our, ours	2nd person	your, yours	you, your	3rd person	He, him, his, she, her, it	they, them, their, theirs
	Singular	Plural												
1st person	I, me, my, mine	we, us, our, ours												
2nd person	your, yours	you, your												
3rd person	He, him, his, she, her, it	they, them, their, theirs												
Adjective	Describes a noun or pronoun	Answers: What kind? Which one? How many? Whose?												
Verb	Shows an action or state of being	Verbs show time. Verb tenses include past, present, and future. Three types: Action- visible or mental Helping- appears before the main verb. Helps the action to occur or shows time. Linking- links the noun or pronoun with a word that identifies or describes it												
Adverb	Describes a verb, adjective or another adverb	Answers: When? How? To what extent?												
Preposition	Shows a relationship between a noun/pronoun and another word in the sentence	Answers: Location? Direction? Time?												
Conjunction	Connects words, groups of words or independent clauses	Three types of conjunctions: Coordinate- used to link or join two words or phrases of equal importance Subordinate- used to join an independent and dependent clause Correlative- pairs of conjunctions used to join groups of words or phrases												
Article	Limits a noun or makes it definite	Two types: Definite Indefinite												
Interjection	Expresses sudden excitement or strong feelings	Usually followed by an exclamation point. *** NOT common in Army writing style.												

To increase the accuracy of your paper, it is important to understand and recognize the nine parts of speech. Figure 6 illustrates examples of each part of speech used in a sentence.

Figure 6

Parts of Speech in Use

Part of Speech	Example
Noun	➤ The <u>students</u> passed the test. ➤ <u>2LT Smith</u> passed the test. ➤ The <u>aircraft</u> arrived late. ➤ I went to the <u>barracks</u> ➤ I went to <u>Riley Barracks</u>. - The Soldier forgot his <u>password</u>.
Pronoun	➤ CPT Brown taught <u>his</u> class. ➤ The Soldiers packed <u>their</u> own lunches. ➤ Have <u>you</u> passed the ACFT?
Adjective	➤ MAJ Jones bought a <u>yellow</u> truck. ➤ <u>Three</u> companies competed in the challenge. ➤ The Soldiers rucked up the <u>steep</u> mountain.
Verb	➤ The tanks <u>collided</u> in the field. (action) ➤ PFC Smith <u>was</u> playing football. (helping) ➤ The Soldiers <u>look</u> tired after the ACFT. (linking)
Adverb	➤ PVT West <u>nearly</u> won the race. ➤ They felt the test was <u>too</u> complicated. ➤ The command team will debrief <u>later</u>.
Preposition	➤ SGT Brown and PFC Jones need equipment <u>in addition</u> to MREs. ➤ The dining facility is <u>next to</u> the barracks. ➤ The Soldiers must ruck <u>through</u> the stream.
Conjunction	➤ GEN White <u>and</u> COL Black will attend the brief. ➤ The Soldiers ran home <u>because</u> it was raining. ➤ They can <u>either</u> eat MREs <u>or</u> order takeout.
Article	➤ SGT Adams spoke to <u>the</u> commanding officer. ➤ SGT Adams spoke to <u>a</u> commanding officer. ➤ SGT Adams spoke to <u>an</u> officer.
Interjection	➤ <u>Ouch!</u> My abs hurt after all those crunches. ➤ <u>Ugh!</u> I do not want to wake up at 0400. ➤ <u>Aha!</u> I finally understand what SGM Doe means.

4-2. Sentence Basics

The parts of speech combine into sentences to create ideas. The subject and predicate are the most basic parts of a sentence as shown in Figure 7.

Figure 7

Subject and Predicate

	Definition	Example
Subject	The person or thing that is doing an action, or the person or thing that is the focus of the sentence.	➤ <u>The commander</u> told me to drink more water. ➤ <u>Soldiers and Civilians</u> will write reports. ➤ <u>CPT Smith</u> holds a review session every Thursday afternoon.
Predicate	The predicate of the sentence is the part that contains the action plus any objects, complements or modifiers.	➤ The commander <u>told me to drink more water.</u> ➤ Soldiers and Civilians <u>will write reports.</u> ➤ CPT Smith <u>holds a review session every Thursday afternoon.</u>

4-3. Subject-Verb Agreement

Subjects come in two forms: singular and plural. Subject-verb agreement is about quantity: if the subject is singular, the verb must be singular; if the subject is plural, the verb must be plural. Figure 8 defines and provides examples of subject-verb agreement.

Figure 8

Subject Verb Agreement

	Subject – Verb Agreement
Definition	Subjects come in two forms: singular and plural. In addition to identifying the subject of the sentence, it is necessary to also identify the verb and conjugate it accordingly. If the subject is singular, then the verb should be singular as well. If the subject is plural, then the verb should also be plural as well.
Examples	➤ The Soldier is available for extra duty. (singular) ➤ The Soldiers are available for extra duty. (plural) ➤ CPT Brown is at the range. (singular) ➤ CPT Brown and his company are at the range. (plural) ➤ The officer has many questions. (singular) ➤ The officers have many questions. (plural)

4-4. Comma Usage

Commas are the most misused punctuation. A comma is a punctuation mark that separates words, clauses, or ideas within a sentence. Figure 9 provides some rules to follow when using the comma.

Figure 9

Comma Rules

Rule	Example
Use commas to separate independent clauses when they are joined by any of these seven coordinating conjunctions: <i>and, but, for, or, nor, so, yet</i> .	➤ The game was over, but the crowd refused to leave. ➤ The student explained her question, yet the instructor still did not seem to understand. ➤ Yesterday was her brother's birthday, so she took him out to dinner.
Use commas after introductory a) clauses, b) phrases, or c) words that come before the main clause.	➤ While I was eating, the cat scratched at the door. (a) ➤ To get a seat, you better come early. (b) ➤ However, you may not be satisfied with the results. (c)

Rule	Example
Use a pair of commas in the middle of a sentence to set off clauses, phrases, and words that are not essential to the meaning of the sentence. Use one comma before to indicate the beginning of the pause and one at the end to indicate the end of the pause.	Here are some clues to help you decide whether the sentence element is essential: - o If you leave out the clause, phrase, or word, does the sentence still make sense? - o Does the clause, phrase, or word interrupt the flow of words in the original sentence? - o If you move the element to a different position in the sentence, does the sentence still make sense? If you answer "yes" to one or more of these questions, then the element in question is nonessential and should be set off with commas. Here are some example sentences with nonessential elements: ➤ Clause: That Tuesday, <i>which happens to be my birthday</i>, is the only day when I am available to meet. ➤ Phrase: This restaurant has an exciting atmosphere. The food, <i>on the other hand</i>, is rather bland. ➤ Word: I appreciate your hard work. In this case, <i>however</i>, you seem to have over-exerted yourself.
Use commas to separate three or more words, phrases, or clauses written in a series.	➤ The Constitution establishes the legislative, executive, and judicial branches of government. ➤ The candidate promised to lower taxes, protect the environment, reduce crime, and end unemployment. ➤ The prosecutor argued that the defendant, who was at the scene of the crime, who had a strong revenge motive, and who had access to the murder weapon, was guilty of homicide.

Rule	Example
Use commas to separate two or more coordinate adjectives that describe the same noun. Be sure never to add an extra comma between the final adjective and the noun itself or to use commas with non-coordinate adjectives.	Coordinate adjectives are adjectives with equal ("co"-ordinate) status in describing the noun; neither adjective is subordinate to the other. You can decide if two adjectives in a row are coordinate by asking the following questions: - o Does the sentence make sense if you write the adjectives in reverse order? - o Does the sentence make sense if you write the adjectives with <i>and</i> between them? ➤ He was a difficult, stubborn child. (coordinate) ➤ They lived in a white frame house. (non-coordinate)
Use a comma near the end of a sentence to separate contrasted coordinate elements or to indicate a distinct pause or shift.	➤ He was merely ignorant, not stupid. ➤ The chimpanzee seemed reflective, almost human. ➤ You are one of the senator's close friends, right? ➤ The speaker seemed innocent, even gullible.
Use commas to set off phrases at the end of the sentence that refer back to the beginning or middle of the sentence. Such phrases are free modifiers that can be placed anywhere in the sentence without causing confusion.	➤ Nancy waved enthusiastically at the docking ship, laughing joyously. ➤ Laughing joyously, Lisa waved at Nancy.
Use commas to set off all geographical names, items in dates (except the month and day), addresses (except the street number and name), and titles in names.	➤ Birmingham, Alabama, gets its name from Birmingham, England. ➤ Rachel B. Lake, MD, will be the principal speaker.
Use a comma to shift between the main discourse and a quotation.	➤ John said without emotion, "I'll see you tomorrow." ➤ "I was able," she answered, "to complete the assignment." ➤ In 1848, Marx wrote, "Workers of the world, unite!"
Use commas wherever necessary to prevent possible confusion or misreading.	➤ To George, Harrison had been a sort of idol.

Note. Purdue Online Writing Lab. (n.d.). *Extended comma rules*. Purdue Online Writing Lab.

https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/punctuation/commas/extended_rules_for_commas.html

4-5. Run-on Sentences

Run-on sentences can be short or long. A long sentence is not necessarily a run-on sentence. Figure 10 provides the two types of run-on sentences, which are the comma splice and the fused sentence. A comma splice occurs when a comma separates two independent clauses. A fused sentence occurs when joining two independent clauses with no punctuation or conjunction between them.

Figure 10

Run-on Sentences

Run-on Sentences		
Types	Definition	Example
Comma Splice	When a comma separates two independent clauses.	➤ PFC Jones was late, she took her time. ➤ SGT Pete earned his CDL, he was still nervous to drive. ➤ GEN White skipped breakfast, he had a headache.
Fused Sentence	Two independent clauses joined with no punctuation or conjunction between them.	➤ 2LT Jones fell asleep in class all the students thought this was funny. ➤ The Soldiers did not want to go to PT it was raining heavily. ➤ DS Hill yelled across the field he was so loud.
- o There are two ways to correct Run-on sentences: ▪ Separate into two or more sentences ▪ Connect the two independent clauses with a conjunction and comma if necessary ➤ PFC Jones was late, so she took her time. ➤ SGT Pete earned his CDL and he was still nervous to drive. ➤ GEN White skipped breakfast because he had a headache. ➤ 2LT Jones fell asleep in class. All the students thought this was funny. ➤ The Soldiers did not want to go to PT. It was raining heavily. ➤ DS Hill yelled across the field. He was so loud.		

4-6. Sentence Fragments

A sentence fragment is a word group written as a sentence but is incomplete. A required sentence part is missing such as a verb or subject. A sentence fragment does not express a complete thought because important information is missing. For a sentence to be complete, it must contain an independent clause as shown in Figure 11.

Figure 11

Sentence Fragments

Sentence Fragments	
Definition	Examples
A sentence fragment is a word group that looks like a sentence but is missing one or more necessary components.	➤ When the Soldier shot the rifle. ➤ Running for formation. ➤ And immediately popped their flares.
o The best way to fix a sentence fragment is to revise it to include the missing component to create an independent clause.	
➤ When the Soldier shot the rifle, he startled the company. ➤ They all began running for formation. ➤ The Soldiers escaped and immediately popped their flares.	

4-7. Capitalization

There are eight primary rules to capitalization; however, several of these rules include exceptions. Follow course guidelines for specific requirements. Figure 12 provides some of the common capitalization rules.

Figure 12*Capitalization*

Capitalization	
Rule	Example
Capitalize the first word in a sentence.	➤ <u>P</u> lease be on time to class.
Capitalize proper nouns and adjectives derived from proper nouns	➤ <u>F</u> ort <u>H</u> uachuca ➤ <u>I</u> talian national
Capitalize titles of person ONLY when used as part of a proper name	➤ <u>S</u> ergeant <u>M</u> ajor <u>J</u> ones ➤ <u>P</u> rofessor <u>C</u> arver
Capitalize on the major words in titles and subtitles of works	➤ <u>U</u> nited <u>S</u> tates <u>A</u> rm <u>y</u> <u>I</u> ntelligence <u>C</u> enter of <u>E</u> xcellence ➤ <u>T</u> rain <u>i</u> ng and <u>D</u> octr <u>i</u> ne <u>C</u> ommand
Capitalize directions that are used as names as section of countries NOT when used as compass directions	➤ PFC Black is from the <u>S</u> outhwest. ➤ The troops deployed to the <u>M</u> iddle <u>E</u> ast.
Capitalize the first word in a sentence that is a direct quote	➤ A popular Army initiative is, "Mission first, people always."
Capitalize words and abbreviations of specific names and government departments or agencies	➤ Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) ➤ United States Military Academy (USMA)
Capitalize time periods and events	➤ World War I ➤ Middle Ages ➤ Roaring Twenties
**Capitalize the word <i>Soldier</i> when referring to a US Soldier **Capitalize the word <i>Family</i> when referring to a US Army Family or Family members **Capitalize the word <i>Civilian</i> when referring to a DA Civilian	

4-8. Punctuation

Without punctuation, writing would not make sense to the reader. Punctuation is as integral to writing as word choice, sentence structure, and content. Figure 13 depicts the different types of punctuation. Please note, commas are a form of punctuation. Please refer to Figure 9 above.

Figure 13*Punctuation*

Punctuation		
Type	When to use	Example
Period	At the end of a sentence; after an in-text citation	➤ PT begins at 0500. ➤ Competent leaders and teams are necessary for effective mission command (HQDA, 2019).
Apostrophe	To show possession of an object	➤ The Soldier's rucksack weighed 45lbs.
Colon	To introduce a list; to separate units of time, proportions and between a title and subtitle	➤ CPT Brown went to the store for some beverages: milk, orange juice and coffee. ➤ The bus left for the schoolhouse at 7:45am. ➤ H is for Honor: A Military Family Alphabet
Semicolon	Used between items in a list or series when the items themselves contain commas; To separate two independent clauses while still demonstrating the close relationship between them	➤ The Soldiers toured Italy, Germany and France in the spring; England, Ireland and Scotland in the fall; and Russia in the winter. ➤ The platoon marched 15 miles; they were exhausted.
En dash	An en dash is for showing a range of numbers.	➤ She lived in Sierra Vista, AZ from 1999-2004.
Em dash	Marks a break in a sentence. Em dashes can be used in pairs to mark off additional information that is not essential to understand the sentence	➤ "You had better get ready – the drill sergeant will be here any minute for inspections!"

Type	When to use	Example
Parentheses	Used to include an explanation or afterthought into a passage that is grammatically complete without the added words; Used to say something important to the main message but is not an immediate part of the message; used to include information that would otherwise interrupt the flow of the message.	➤ Joe (accompanied by his trusty mutt) was always welcome. ➤ I lost my phone (a Samsung S9) yesterday during morning PT. ➤ Next week we will study the hydrologic cycle (also known as the water cycle).
Quotation Marks	Used to set off and represent exact language (either spoken or written) that has come from someone else.	➤ CPT Smith reminded his 1SG, "Don't forget to bring water to the training exercise."
Use colons, semicolons, dashes, and parenthesis infrequently. These types of punctuation are not concise and impede the rapid read.		

4-9. Quotation Marks

According to AR 25-50, use boldface or italic type to emphasize a specific or important fact. Avoid using quotation marks for emphasis as this impedes the rapid read and can be confused with directly quoted outside information. Do not overuse this method for emphasis. In general, substitute more specific or forceful words to gain emphasis. Writers use quotation marks with direct quotes and should use quotation marks when they want to use someone else's words in their writing. Capitalize the first letter of quoted text if quoting a complete sentence. If quoting a portion of the sentence, the first letter should be lowercase. Once you open quotation marks, you must close them. Block quotations do not use quotation marks. Use single quotation marks instead of parentheses for translation, but in that case, there is no need to separate by commas.

- a. *Example of direct quote:* According to AR 25-50, "In accordance with Plain Writing Act of 2010, Public Law (PL) No. 111 – 274, DA writing will be clear, concise, and well-organized" (HQDA, 2020, p.2).
- b. *Example:* According to AR 25-50, "correspondence must be free of errors in grammar, mechanics, and usage" (HQDA, 2020, p.2).
- c. *Example:* CPT Smith, from the French Army, told him *bon jour* 'good day' when they met.

4-10. Numbers

If a sentence starts with a number, spell it out or re-write the sentence so the number does not begin the sentence. According to the *Army Style Guide*, if a number is less than 10, spell it out (United States Army, 2017).

In most cases, units of measurement, time and money, appear as numerals, unless the time is nonliteral or indefinite – ex – in a day or two, finish by the eleventh hour, lasted more than four decades.

For decades or centuries use wording, not numerals – ex – in the last three decades.

If a number is part of a name, spell it out – ex – Air Force One, Three Rivers, PA.

Generally, numerals are fine for dates, addresses, percentages, fractions, decimals, scores, statistics, and exact amounts of money.

There are always exceptions when it comes to numbers, and they will depend upon your course. If the course prefers you use figures over spelling out numbers, or vice versa, always do what is asked. Be adaptable and always refer to the formatting requirement when necessary.

4-11. Italics

Italics is a slanting font style used in printed material. Different style guides have different standards regarding the use of italics. Below, in Figure 14, are some general rules regarding italicizing words. Always consult with your instructors and follow their guidance.

Figure 14*Italics*

Italics	
Rule	Example
Italicize the titles of magazines, books, newspapers, academic journals, films, television shows, long poems, plays of three or more acts, operas, musical albums, works of art, websites	➤ <i>Time</i> ➤ <i>Romeo and Juliet</i> by William Shakespeare
Italicize aircraft, vessels and spacecraft	➤ <i>USS Wisconsin</i> ➤ <i>Apollo 13</i>
Italicize foreign words.	➤ <i>Semper fi</i>, the motto of the U.S. Marine Corps, means “always faithful.”
Italicize a word or phrase to add emphasis.	➤ The <i>truth</i> is of utmost concern.
Italicize a word when referring to that word.	➤ The word <i>justice</i> is often misunderstood and therefore misused.
Italicize names of legal cases	➤ <i>Smith v. Brown</i>

4-12. Figurative Language

Army writing style is different from creative or literary styles, which utilize figurative language. This type of language can detract from conveying the purpose of your paper. In Army writing, it is best to be as literal as possible and avoid figurative language, as it will impede the single, rapid reading. To avoid the use of figurative language in Army correspondence, it is important that you can recognize it. Figure 15 provides a list of the different types of figurative language. This chart will help you identify figurative language throughout your writing. As a reminder, avoid the use of figurative language as it is not concise.

Figure 15*Figurative Language*

Figurative Language		
Type	Definition	Example
Simile	A comparison between two things using like or as	➤ CPT and 1SG fought <u>like</u> cats and dogs.
Metaphor	A direct comparison between two things without using comparative words	➤ The <u>tall trees were curtains</u> that provided us cover and concealment.
Alliteration	Repetition of the same consonant sound at the start of one or more words near one another in a sentence	➤ The <u>cl</u> amoring <u>cr</u> ash of the <u>cr</u> ates during my PCS startled me.
Personification	Attributing human characteristics to non-human things	➤ SGT Smith's <u>heart jumped</u> when he overslept and missed PT.
Onomatopoeia	Descriptive words that mimic the noise they are describing	➤ PV2 Walker's stomach <u>grumbled</u> as they entered the chow hall.
Oxymoron	Using two opposite ideas to create an effective description	➤ The <u>loud silence</u> of the night kept CPT Brown awake.
Hyperbole	An over exaggeration used to emphasize emotion or description	➤ PFC Blackwell was <u>so hungry</u> after the ruck march he said <u>he would eat dirt</u> .
Allusion	Reference to a well-known person, place, thing or historical event. It requires the reader to use background knowledge to understand the meaning	➤ She was the <u>Helen of Troy</u> of the class.
Cliché	A phrase or opinion that is overused and betrays a lack of original thought	➤ Ft. Huachuca is a <u>diamond in the rough</u> .

Type	Definition	Example
Idiom	A commonly used expression that has acquired a meaning different from its literal meaning; a phrase that holds meaning with a group of people	➤ COL Brown has a <u>green thumb</u> .
Colloquialism	A word or phrase that is not formal or literary, typically one used in ordinary or familiar conversation	➤ Y'all ➤ Gonna ➤ Ain't
Jargon	Terminology only understood by people in a certain group	➤ BLUF ➤ Galley

4-13. Point of View

First, second, and third person are ways of describing points of view as shown in Figure 16.

Figure 16

Point of View

Point of View			
Type	Definition	Pronouns	Example
First Person	The writer is writing from his or her own perspective. This also means their bias is included.	I, me, my, mine, we, us, our, ours	➤ I exited the secure room with classified documents in my hand.
Second Person	The writer forces the reader into the story. The perspective of the audience the writer is addressing.	You, your, yours	➤ You exited the secure room with classified documents in your hand.
Third Person	The perspective of the person or people about whom the writer is writing.	He, him, his, she, her, it, they, them, their, theirs	➤ She exited the secure room with classified documents in her hand.

Chapter 5 Voice

Voice refers to who or what is performing the action. An essential requirement in effective Army writing is using active voice. The Army prefers the use of active voice rather than passive voice in correspondence because it emphasizes the actor as opposed to the receiver. In passive voice sentences, the subject passively receives the action of the verb. Most writing style guides prefer active voice because it simplifies the sentences, often shortens their length, and reveals who or what is performing the action.

5-1. Active Voice

- a. Emphasizes the subject (actor) of the sentence.
- b. Puts the actor before the verb (action).
- c. Places the descriptive object (receiver) at the end of the sentence.

Instructors will look at how much of the paper is in active voice or passive voice and note if it interferes with the clarity of the assignment.

5-2. Active versus Passive

The simple definition of active voice is the subject of a sentence performs the verb's action. AR 25-50 recommends using simple sentences with a clear subject (actor), and active verb (action), and a descriptive object (receiver).

- a. Active voice:

Example: Soldiers compose multiple papers.

Explanation: Soldiers (subject) compose (verb) multiple papers (object).

Example: 2LT Ripley passed the physical fitness test.

Explanation: 2LT (subject) passed (verb) the physical fitness test (object).

In both examples, the Soldiers and 2LT Ripley are the ones doing the action to the object.

The simple definition of passive voice is when the subject of the sentence is acted on by the verb. Passive voice uses different forms of the verb *to be* (am, is, was, were, are, be, being, become, been, and sometimes got or get) before the past participle (verb forms ending in -d or -ed) of the sentence's main verb. However, while passive sentences include a past participle, they are not necessarily in the past tense. Passive sentences can appear in any tense.

b. Passive voice:

Example: Multiple papers are composed by the Soldiers.

Explanation: Multiple papers (object) are composed (verb) by the Soldiers (subject).

Example: The physical fitness test was passed by 2LT Ripley.

Explanation: The physical fitness test (object) was passed (verb) by 2LT Ripley (subject).

In both examples, multiple papers and the physical fitness test are the object receiving the action.

5-3. Passive to Active

The key to changing passive voice to active is to find the action and who or what is doing the action. Some passive voice sentences may not identify an actor. Follow these steps to turn passive into active.

- a. Carefully consider who or what is performing the action expressed with the verb. This will be the actor. Sometimes it will follow the terms *by* or *by the* (subject).
- b. Make that actor the subject of the sentence. Do this by putting the actor in front of the verb.
 Passive: The report was submitted by *SGT Jones*.
 Revised: *SGT Jones* submitted the report.
- c. Change the verb so it agrees with the subject and adjust the rest of the sentence.
 Passive: The report *was submitted* by SGT Jones.
 Revised: SGT Jones *submitted* the report.

Active sentences should follow: Actor/Subject (who is doing the action) > Action/Verb (what is being done) > Object (who or what the action is being done to)

5-4. Unknown Actor

Sometimes you will need to infer the actor from the surrounding sentences, if they provide context. In some cases, short passive voice sentences come at the expense of the subject. For example:

- a. The door was kicked. (Four words, passive voice)
- b. I kicked the door. (Four words, active voice)

Note. The second sentence in active voice identifies the subject. Now, compare the two sentences when we add the subject:

- a. The door was kicked by me. (Six words, passive voice)
- b. I kicked the door. (Four words, active voice)

5-5. Examples Using Got

Figure 17

Using Got

Passive using Got	Regular Passive	Active Voice
He got attacked by a bear.	He was attacked by a bear.	The bear attacked him.
Their car got stolen.	Their car was stolen.	Someone stole their car.
CPT Smith got promoted to Major.	CPT Smith was promoted to Major.	The Army promoted CPT Smith to major.

5-6. More Examples

Figure 18 provides additional examples on how to change a sentence from passive voice to active voice.

Figure 18

Passive to Active

Passive	Active
The report was written by the commander.	The commander wrote the report.
The old car was driven by PFC Walker.	PFC Walker drove the old car.
Their rifles were cleaned last month.	The Soldiers cleaned their rifles last month.
The government vehicle was destroyed by the storm.	The storm destroyed the government vehicle.

5-7. By Zombies

One tip for finding passive voice in a sentence is to insert the words, *By Zombies* (or any Subject) next to the verb. If the verb is in active voice or the verb *to be* only describes a state of being, then adding the extra SUBJECT will make it more, not less, confusing. Figure 19 illustrates how to utilize the *By Zombies* method as an additional tool to recognize passive voice.

Figure 19*By Zombies*

Original	By Zombies	Makes sense?	Conclusion
The door was kicked in.	The door <u>was kicked in</u> ... <i>by zombies?</i>	Yes	PASSIVE
The supplies <u>were lost</u> somewhere on the trail.	The supplies <u>were lost</u> ... <i>by zombies?</i>	Yes	PASSIVE
The bill for the restaurant <u>was paid</u> before we arrived.	The bill for the restaurant <u>was paid</u> ... <i>by zombies?</i>	Yes	PASSIVE
I washed the tank three weeks ago.	I washed the tank three weeks ago... <i>by zombies?</i>	No	ACTIVE

While passive voice is grammatically correct, the Army discourages the use of it, as it is not concise. The most effective choice is active voice.

Chapter 6 Analysis

As an intelligence professional, you will analyze a problem, process information from various sources, and report your findings through an intelligence product. You will either analyze a problem and report your findings or argue and defend your analysis.

6-1. Analysis

Analysis is a systematic thinking process that:

- a. Closely examines an idea, object, belief, or situation;
- b. Breaks down each piece of information;
- c. Studies and describes the relationships;
- d. Shows connection between individual pieces as they relate to the whole.

Analysis is a detailed examination of the elements or structure of something. Analysis requires you to analyze, evaluate, interpret, and integrate outside sources to offer a complete idea with resources to support the claims. Once you work through this process, you will break down each piece of information to assess and describe the relationships. The final product will show how the pieces of the analysis relate or connect to each other. This is a necessary skill for any intelligence professional.

Instructors will watch for the building of facts and the connections that show how the facts relate to the claim of the paper.

In contrast to summary, which describes what something is, analysis investigates *why* the pieces of information exists and *how* they operate together.

6-2. Getting Started

The easiest way to recognize analysis is to compare it to summary as shown in Figure 20. Summary describes who, what, where, and when. Analysis breaks down the *why* and *how* behind the details.

Figure 20

Summary versus Analysis

Summary (of Data)		Analysis (Claims)	
Who?	CPT Thomas: a competitive athlete CPT Harrison: best runner on post	Why?	CPT Thomas wants to break his personal best
What?	Showed up in running gear		
Where?	At the PT field with a track	How?	By practicing against the best runner on post, CPT Harrison
When?	At 0530 on Saturday		

Note. The summary includes only reliable data. There is no room for debate in these facts beyond their accuracy. CPT Thomas either is or is not a competitive athlete; similarly, CPTs Thomas and Harrison either did or did not show up at 0530 in running gear.

In the analysis, there may be additional reasons why CPTs Thomas and Harrison showed up at the running field. Based on this data, the analysis is a reasonable guess; however, the strength of the analysis depends on the evidence available.

6-3. Analysis Task

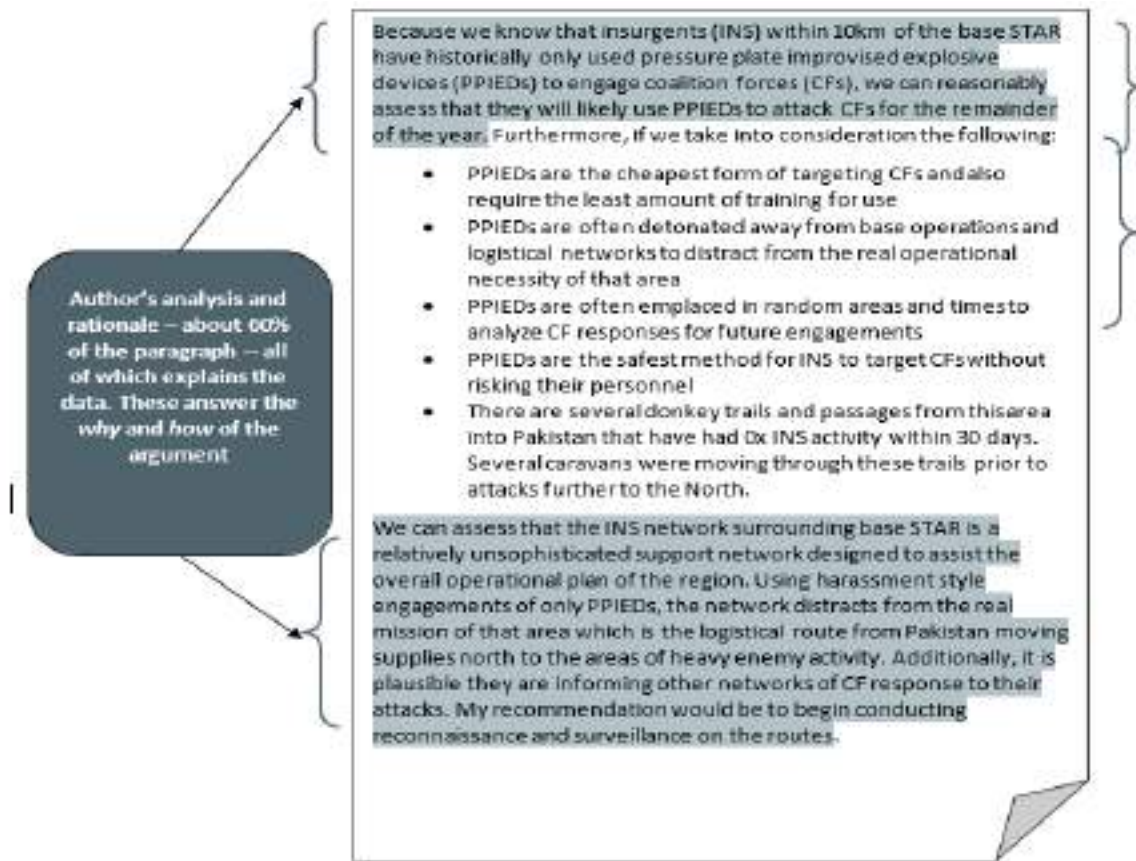
It is important to know what you are going to analyze. Your instructor will give you the task and topic. Remember, analysis focuses on the *how* and *why* of a situation, idea, object, belief, or relationship. Most writers have difficulty with finding and interpreting the data. You must look at the facts and research you have gathered, then figure out your viewpoint and what claim or statement you want to make about it.

As you write, think about two things: the reader and the product. Your reader will be making a decision based on the information you provide. You must think about what they already know, and what they might want to know. Do they already understand the final analysis, or are you introducing something new? What will they do with the information you are giving them? Make sure you are in-depth with your analysis, if you do not give enough information, or give too much information, the point may be underdeveloped or lost.

6-4. Example of an Analytical Paragraph

Figure 21 shows a sample paragraph illustrating detailed analysis and summary.

Note, while the paragraph contains five bullet points of summary data, the author maintains issue-focus by drawing conclusions from the facts of primary sources.

Figure 21*Analysis***6-5. Intelligence Community Analytic Standards**

As a member of the Intelligence Community, it is important to understand the Intelligence Community Analytical Standards. The Intelligence Community Directive (ICD) established the following standards in ICD 203 to guide analysis and analytic production.

- Objective
- Independent of political consideration
- Timely
- Based on all available sources of intelligence information
- Implements and exhibits Analytical Tradecraft Standards- Refer to ICD 203 for further explanation of the Analytical Tradecraft Standards

To emphasize the analysis in your paper, it is important use the appropriate analytical terms. ICD 203 provides the following terminology depicted in Figure 22.

Figure 22

Analytical Terms

Likelihood	Almost no chance	Very unlikely	Unlikely	Roughly even chance	Likely	Very likely	Almost certain(ly)
Probability/ confidence level	Remote	Highly improbable	Improbable (improbably)	Roughly even odds	Probable (probably)	Highly probable	Nearly certain
Odds	01-05%	05-20%	20-45%	45-55%	55-80%	80-95%	95-99%

Most paper assignments will require analysis. As you develop your analysis, use the analytical terms to demonstrate the difference between analysis and summary. Remember, analysis is a detailed examination of the elements or structure of something, and the intent is to show the relationship between the pieces and how they relate to each other.

Glossary

Accuracy: Using correct grammar, wording, and formatting. Having an essay free from errors.

Active Voice: A type of a clause or sentence in which a subject performs an action and expresses it through its representative verb.

Adjective: A word or phrase added to a noun to modify or describe it.

Adjective pronoun: Any pronoun functioning as an adjective. For example, “This car looks like a Fiat.”

Adverb: a word or phrase used to modify an adjective, verb, or another adverb expressing a relation of place, time, circumstance, manner, cause, or degree.

Analysis: a detailed examination of the elements or structure of something

Argue: changing the mind of the reader to adopt an idea or course of action using facts, statistics, and figures

Awkward shift: A change in sentence structure, usually from mismatched pronoun use, shift in verb tense, or change in number of the subject from singular to plural or vice versa.

Bottom Line Up Front: The *bottom line up front* or BLUF states the main purpose of the document at the beginning. Originally defined in AR 25-50 for correspondence, USAICoE recommends using the term as a principle for all Army writing. Regardless of the writing situation, Army style encourages writers to prioritize their conclusions to create reader-friendly documents.

Concision: Concision is the ability to infuse the greatest amount of information into the fewest words. For USAICoE, this is a core criterion of all writing.

Conjunction: This part of speech joins phrases and clauses to form extended ideas.

Coordinating conjunction: A conjunction placed between words, phrases, clauses, or sentences of equal rank, e.g., and, but, or.

Credibility: The status and reputation of an author while presenting evidence. It sometimes refers to authors' experiences, backgrounds, or characteristics as they relate to being a trustworthy source of information for the purpose of an argument.

Dependent Clause: A group of words with a subject and a verb. It does not express a complete thought so it is not a sentence and can't stand alone.

Evaluation (of sources): A process of determining the relative strength of a research source towards contributing to an argument. Evaluation requires the author's discretion and judgment to determine the value of the source.

Federal Plain Language Guidelines: Emerged as a government effort to simplify complicated laws, regulation, and records.

Front: This describes the location near the top of the page or writing unit. The closer to the front of the document, the less time it takes the reader to get there.

Frontloading: A writing technique that places the most important information at the front of the document, section, paragraph, or sentence. During the drafting process, some writers may find their insights occur near the end of paragraphs or within the conclusion section as they develop ideas by writing them out. It is critical to revise papers later by reorganizing these conclusions as priorities in the text.

Independent Clause: A clause that can stand alone as a simple sentence.

Interjection: An exclamation, often used with an exclamation mark.

Jargon: Terminology only understood by people in a certain group.

Main Point: An explicit or implied statement indicating the author's purpose in creating the document. In Army writing, state the main point as quickly, clearly, and succinctly as possible without losing the overall meaning of the point.

Noun: A person, place, animal, thing, or idea.

Object: Receives the action performed by the subject and verb. For example, "Critics often dismiss heroism."

Paraphrase: The restating of another's idea into your own words.

Passive Voice: A clause or sentence in which an action (through verb), or an object of a sentence, is emphasized rather than its subject.

Personal pronoun: A word that refers to a stated noun (a specific person, place, or thing). For example, "The Soldiers stood out on the parade ground. They looked pretty serious."

Plagiarism: The accidental or purposeful misrepresentation of original work as someone else's. Typically occurs in documents requiring original insight where the author either does not cite another source properly or purposefully injects a source without recognizing the original.

Preposition: This part of speech links strings of nouns and pronouns into phrases to modify other parts of the sentence.

Pronoun: A word that refers to a stated noun.

Proper Noun: Identifies a single entity and is used to refer to that entity, such as London, Jupiter, Sarah, or Microsoft, as distinguished from a common noun.

Purpose: The specific reason explaining why the document, correspondence, or report is necessary.

Signal Phrases: Short clauses intended to indicate the introduction of a non-original source or transition to a new idea.

Subject (of a sentence): Usually precedes the verb and signifies the main idea.

Summary: A condensed version of a topic, usually in reference to another author's work.

Verb: Conveys the action of a sentence between the subject and the predicate. Usually, the action is dynamic, but it can also express a state of being by using the verb "to be."

Voice: Refers to who or what is performing the action.

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